

Case - Educational Delivery and Medical Care – Partnerships between The University of the West Indies and Medical Facilities across the Caribbean

The University of the West Indies (The UWI) began its journey in 1948, welcoming just 33 medical students to its first faculty, Medicine, at Mona, Jamaica. Back then, it was the University College of the West Indies (UCWI), affiliated with the University of London. To support the clinical training of its students, a hospital was essential, and so, in 1949, the University College Hospital of the West Indies (UCHWI) was established. By 1967, it had evolved into The University Hospital of the West Indies (UHWI), which has grown to become the largest teaching hospital in the Caribbean, sitting right next to the Mona campus. UHWI has been the practical arm of the Faculty of Medical Sciences, offering care while doubling as a teaching and research facility. With around 580 beds, intensive care units, multiple operating theatres, and specialised services like telemedicine through the Hugh Wynter Fertility Management Unit, UHWI plays a critical role in delivering medical education and healthcare services.

The UWI didn't stop at Mona. In 1967, the same year UHWI got its current name, it expanded clinical training to its Cave Hill Campus in Barbados. That move sparked a longstanding partnership with the Queen Elizabeth Hospital (QEH), which still serves as the teaching hospital for that campus. Initially, medical students studied their basic sciences in Jamaica before heading to Barbados for clinical training. Today, the full medical programme is offered at Cave Hill, with QEH at the heart of both undergraduate and postgraduate education. Much like UHWI, QEH supports not just clinical training but also research and professional development, with many of its medical staff serving as lecturers or clinical instructors. These collaborations reflect The UWI's broader commitment to improving healthcare and training professionals to meet the region's needs.

UHWI, despite its legacy, faces real challenges in information management. Many operations remain paper-based, and digital systems that do exist are disconnected. In patient care and lab settings, data on patients, their health status, caregivers, and billing is often collected manually. This not only leads to repeated data entry, wasting time and frustrating patients and staff alike, but also disrupts the flow of care. Patients are often asked to repeat the same information multiple times throughout their visit, delaying service and complicating the hospital's ability to operate efficiently. Recognising this, stakeholders have called for an integrated Hospital Information Management System (HIMS). Such a system would ensure that patient data is entered once and accessed by authorised personnel throughout the hospital. It would streamline operations, reduce redundancy, and let healthcare workers focus on what matters most - caring for patients. Picture a parent anxiously arriving at UHWI after their child has been injured at school. Instead of being bounced from desk to desk for answers, a customer service rep could quickly locate the child and provide updates, all thanks to a centralised, digital system.

Beyond UHWI and QEH, The UWI has formed critical partnerships with other hospitals throughout the Caribbean, enhancing its regional mission in medical education, clinical training, and research. In Trinidad and Tobago, the Eric Williams Medical Sciences Complex (EWMSC) is a vital hub, closely tied to the St. Augustine Campus and home to the Faculty of Medical Sciences. This facility supports training in medicine, dentistry, veterinary medicine, and pharmacy, and includes specialist units like

the Adult and Paediatric Hospitals, the National Radiotherapy Centre, and the Dental School. Also, in Trinidad, the Port-of-Spain and San Fernando General Hospitals provide clinical exposure, particularly for postgraduate students in areas like internal medicine and surgery. Many senior clinicians at these sites also hold academic appointments with The UWI.

In The Bahamas, the Princess Margaret Hospital supports students through the School of Clinical Medicine and Research (SCMR), contributing to programmes such as the Doctor of Medicine (DM) in Internal Medicine and Paediatrics. In St. Vincent and the Grenadines, the Milton Cato Memorial Hospital hosts students for clinical training and elective rotations. Similarly, Saint Lucia's Owen King EU Hospital (formerly Victoria Hospital) has been used for clerkships, and Tobago's Scarborough General Hospital supports both undergraduate and postgraduate training. These regional partnerships enable students to learn in diverse healthcare environments and better understand the unique needs of different populations.

The UWI's model of regional integration is not just functional, it's visionary. It supports professional development, facilitates collaborative research, and promotes public health outreach across the Caribbean. With initiatives like the proposed HIMs and a strong network of hospital partnerships, The UWI continues to bridge education, service, and technology in pursuit of more efficient, patient-focused healthcare.

It is important to note that The UWI is a single, regional, institution with divisions (campuses) across the Caribbean. These divisions collaborate with entities in the country in which they (the divisions) operate. The UWI is run by a Chief Executive Officer or *de facto* institutional president (the **Vice Chancellor**) and each division is headed by a divisional president or institutional vice president (a Pro Vice Chancellor), who is also the Campus Principal. There are 5 divisions: The **Five Islands Campus** (Antigua and Barbuda); The **Cave Hill Campus** (Barbados); The **Global Campus** (online and with locations across 16 Caribbean countries); The **Mona Campus** (Jamaica); and The **St Augustine Campus** (Trinidad and Tobago).

Institutional arrangements, although implemented at the divisional level, are brokered/negotiated and driven / partially monitored centrally (from the administrative section referred to as the Vice Chancellery) headquartered at The UWI's Regional Headquarters in Kingston, Jamaica. In addition to the divisional vice presidents, three other vice presidents (Pro Vice Chancellors) form part of The UWI's Executive Management team. These are: the Pro Vice Chancellor (**PVC Graduate Studies and Research**); the **PVC Undergraduate Studies**; and the **PVC for Global Affairs**. Other members of the Executive Management Team include: the vice president for Finance (the **University Bursar**) and the vice president for Human Resource Management and Operations (the **University Registrar**).

All PVCs report to the Vice Chancellor (VC) and the Executive Management team is overseen by a board (**University Council**) with its chairman being the **Chancellor** of the University. This means that the VC reports to University Council directly.